

Yasuyuki Yasuda was accidentally shot dead by one of the other attackers. Tsuyoshi Okudaira was killed by one of his own grenades, either due to premature detonation or a suicide. Kōzō Okamoto was wounded and captured trying to escape the terminal.^[4]

Trial and release

Okamoto was put on trial in an Israeli military court under the 1948 Emergency Regulations. His court-appointed lawyers were Max Kritzman and David Rotlevy; Kritzman, who was chief lawyer, had experience defending Israelis charged under the Emergency Regulations. Of Okamoto, he complained that "this man will not cooperate".^[7] Okamoto pleaded guilty, ensuring that he did not get sentenced to death. He also protested his attorneys' requests for a psychiatric evaluation. In his final statement Okamoto told the court: "When I was a child, I was told that when people died they became stars...We three Red Army soldiers wanted to become Orion when we died".^[6]

Okamoto was convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment in Israel. During the incarceration, he requested to convert to Judaism and tried to circumcise himself with nail clippers.^[8] He stated that he was tortured during his imprisonment, being "forced to eat like a dog" and emerged from imprisonment emaciated.^[9]

On 20 July 1973, PFLP and JRA operatives hijacked Japan Air Lines Flight 404,^[10] demanding Okamoto's release in exchange for the hostages on board; Israel refused to comply. Okamoto was released in 1985 after 13 years in prison, as part of the Jibril Agreement, a prisoner exchange with Palestinian militant factions for captive Israeli soldiers. After his release from prison in Israel, Kōzō Okamoto moved to Libya, then Syria, and finally to Lebanon where he reunited with other members of the Japanese Red Army.

Asylum in Lebanon

On February 15, 1997, Lebanon detained five Red Army members, Haruo Wakō, Masao Adachi, Mariko Yamamoto, Kazuo Tohira and Okamoto for using forged passports and visa violations. They were sentenced to three years in prison. The sentence was passed by Judge Soheil Abdul-Shams on 31 July 1997. After their prison term was completed, the four other members of the JRA were forcibly deported to Jordan and from Amman, Jordan via a chartered Russian plane to Japan. The Lebanese government, however, granted political asylum to Okamoto because, according to the Lebanese government, he "had participated in resistance operations against Israel and had been tortured in Israeli jails".^[11]

Okamoto is still wanted by the Japanese police and Japan has requested his extradition.^[12] As of 2016, he was reported to be living in a refugee camp near Beirut.^[13]

In May 2017, Okamoto gave an interview to the Mainichi Shimbun in Beirut. He said "I want to return to Japan once".^[14]

On 30 May 2022, Okamoto appeared at a ceremony in Beirut marking the 50th anniversary of the attack, laying a wreath on the graves of his fellow JRA militants and posing for photos with PFLP supporters.^[15]

See also

- [Aharon Katzir](#), recipient of the Israeli Prize in life science, one of the Lod Airport massacre victims
- [Fusako Shigenobu](#), communist leader of the terrorist group, the [Japanese Red Army](#).

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